Uncle Tom's Cabin

Harriet Beecher Stowe · 1852 · selected passages

Source: Project Gutenberg, gutenberg.org/ebooks/203 (1852 first-edition text).

Harriet Beecher Stowe wrote Uncle Tom's Cabin in serial form in 1851–52 as a moral indictment of slavery, motivated specifically by the Fugitive Slave Act of 1850. The novel sold 300,000 copies in its first year and became the best-selling American novel of the 19th century. Apocryphal or not, Lincoln's reported greeting to Stowe — 'so this is the little woman who made this great war' — captures how widely the book was read on both sides of the sectional divide.

Connect: The 'peculiar institution' you're reading about now is what the Wilmot Proviso (Class 17) tried to keep OUT of new territories. Why did white Southern leaders defend it as a 'positive good' by the 1830s?

Key Passages

Eliza crossing the ice (Chapter VII)

> The huge green fragment of ice on which she alighted pitched and creaked as her weight came on it, but she stayed there not a moment. With wild cries and desperate energy she leaped to another and still another cake — stumbling, leaping, slipping, springing upwards again. Her shoes are gone — her stockings cut from her feet — while blood marked every step…

On the Fugitive Slave Act

> There is one thing that every individual can do — they can see to it that they FEEL right. An atmosphere of sympathetic influence encircles every human being; and the man or woman who feels strongly, healthily and justly, on the great interests of humanity, is a constant benefactor to the human race.

Tom's death scene (Chapter XLI)

> 'Who, — who, — who shall separate us from the love of Christ?' he said, in a voice that contended with mortal weakness; and, with a smile, he fell asleep.

HAPP Analysis

Model answers fill the first three rows. Use them to explain the author's Purpose in the last row.

HAPP Element	Your Analysis
Historical Context *What was happening when this was written?*	The Compromise of 1850 included a stronger Fugitive Slave Act that required Northerners to help capture people escaping slavery.
Intended Audience *Who was the source written for?*	Northern white middle-class readers, especially women and Christian families, who first read it in serial form in the antislavery newspaper The National Era.
Point of View *Whose perspective? Whose is missing?*	Harriet Beecher Stowe, a white Northern woman from a family of ministers and reformers who opposed slavery on moral and religious grounds.

HAPP Element	Your Analysis
Purpose *What did the author want to accomplish?*	

Analysis Prompts

1. DBQ Thesis (1 pt): Write a defensible thesis on the role of cultural texts (novels, songs, sermons) in deepening the sectional crisis of the 1850s.

2. Why was the Fugitive Slave Act of 1850 specifically the trigger for Stowe?

3. How might a Southern reader and a Northern reader have responded to the same passage?